

Appendix G — Dequad Safeguarding Protocol

Document classification: Confidential **Owner:** Dequad Ltd (in formation) **Clinical sign-off:** [Clinical Advisor Name, qualifications, registration number] **Document version:** 1.0 — February 2026 **Review cadence:** Quarterly (or immediately following any Category-A incident) **Submitted as:** Appendix G of the Dequad UK Innovator Founder Visa Business Plan

1. Purpose

This protocol defines how Dequad detects, escalates, and audits safeguarding concerns arising from user activity on the Dequad mobile platform. It is aligned to:

- **UK Universities (UUK) Mental Health Charter** (2020, updated)
- **Office for Students (OfS) Regulatory Framework — Condition B3**
- **UK Data Protection Act 2018** and **UK GDPR**
- **Prevent Duty** statutory guidance (where applicable)
- **NHS Digital DTAC** (Digital Technology Assessment Criteria) — Dequad's target compliance level

It applies to all Dequad personnel, contractors, and university partner welfare leads.

2. Definitions

Term	Definition
User	A .ac.uk -verified UK university student aged 18+ using Dequad.
Welfare Lead	The designated safeguarding contact at a partner UK university.
Safeguarding Concern	Any content, behaviour or pattern that indicates a user may be at risk of harm to self or others.
Category-A Incident	Imminent risk of life (e.g., active suicidal intent, ongoing self-harm, threat to others).
Category-B Incident	Moderate risk (e.g., expressions of severe distress, persistent low mood patterns, disordered eating signals).
Category-C Incident	Low risk / early warning (e.g., isolation indicators, declining mood-tracking patterns).
DSL	Designated Safeguarding Lead — Dequad's internal lead (CEO / Clinical Advisor).

3. Detection — How Concerns Surface

3.1 Automated Keyword Detection

A curated, clinically-reviewed taxonomy of UK English (and common regional dialect) phrases is scanned **in real time** against: - Direct messages (chat content) - Mood-tracking free-text reflections - Profile prompt responses

The taxonomy is grouped into three severity bands aligned to Categories A / B / C above. The full keyword list is held as a trade secret and reviewed quarterly by the Clinical Advisor. Examples (illustrative, not exhaustive):

Category	Example keyword themes
A	Active suicidal phrasing, specific method references, immediate plan language
B	Persistent self-loathing language, repeated hopelessness phrasing, severe eating-related distress
C	Persistent isolation phrasing, sleep-disturbance patterns, sudden withdrawal from app

3.2 Pattern-Based Detection

In addition to keyword triggers, Dequad monitors **behavioural patterns** that may indicate risk:

- Sudden drop in mood score (>3 points week-on-week)
- Stopped logging mood for 14+ days following negative trend
- Repeated late-night activity combined with negative sentiment
- Rapid increase in messages with safeguarding keywords (escalation pattern)

3.3 User Self-Report

Users can tap "I need help" in-app at any time, which triggers an immediate Category-A surface of UK crisis resources and (with explicit user opt-in only) notification to their university welfare lead.

3.4 Peer Report

Users can report another user. Reports are reviewed within **2 hours** during UK business hours, **6 hours** out-of-hours, by Dequad trained moderators.

4. Escalation Workflow

4.1 Category-A (Imminent Risk)

Step	Action	Owner	Timing
1	Alert is generated automatically by the detection engine	System	Immediate
2	In-app overlay surfaces to the user with UK crisis resources (Samaritans 116 123, Shout 85258, NHS 111 option 2, local A&E)	System	Immediate (<5 sec)
3	SMTP email + push notification to the partner university's designated Welfare Lead	System	<60 seconds
4	SMS to Dequad on-call Safeguarding Officer	System	<60 seconds
5	If university Welfare Lead unreachable within 30 minutes → escalation to Dequad Clinical Advisor for direct user contact	Human (Clinical Advisor)	30 min
6	Audit entry written to immutable safeguarding log	System	Real time
7	Incident review within 24 hours; lessons-learned applied to taxonomy if needed	DSL + Clinical Advisor	<24 hr

4.2 Category-B (Moderate Risk)

Step	Action	Owner	Timing
1	Alert generated	System	Immediate
2	In-app gentle prompt offering UK signposting resources	System	<1 min
3	Email notification to university Welfare Lead (non-urgent, batched daily 9am digest)	System	Within 24 hr
4	Welfare Lead reviews and decides on appropriate university-side response	Human (Welfare Lead)	Within 72 hr
5	Audit entry written	System	Real time

4.3 Category-C (Low Risk / Early Warning)

Step	Action	Owner	Timing
1	Pattern logged in anonymised analytics	System	Real time
2	User shown personalised wellbeing content in-app (gentle, non-alarming)	System	Next session
3	Appears in aggregate anonymised welfare team dashboard	System	Weekly refresh
4	No individual escalation unless pattern persists or worsens to B/A	n/a	n/a

5. UK Crisis Resources Presented In-App

All crisis surface points display **UK-specific** resources only:

Resource	When shown
Samaritans — 116 123 (free, 24/7, UK)	Category A, on-demand
Shout — text 85258 (free, 24/7, UK)	Category A & B
NHS 111 , option 2 (mental health)	Category A & B
999 / A&E (medical emergency)	Category A only, with explicit "if you are in immediate danger" framing
CALM — 0800 58 58 58 (5pm–midnight)	Optional, men's mental health
Papyrus HOPELINE247 — 0800 068 4141 (under-35s suicide prevention)	Category A & B (age-appropriate)
Mind Infoline — 0300 123 3393	Category C
University-specific welfare team contact	All categories, university-specific

6. Data Protection & Privacy

6.1 Lawful Basis (UK GDPR Art. 6 & Art. 9)

Data Type	Lawful Basis
General user data	Art. 6(1)(b) — performance of contract
Mental health-related signals	Art. 9(2)(a) — explicit consent AND Art. 9(2)(c) — vital interests for Category-A only
Safeguarding alert to university	Art. 6(1)(d) — vital interests + Art. 9(2)(c) for sensitive data

Users **explicitly consent** to the safeguarding flow during onboarding via a granular, plain-English consent screen (no dark patterns, no pre-ticked boxes).

6.2 Data Minimisation

The minimum amount of data needed for the safeguarding decision is shared with the Welfare Lead: - Category-A: user identity + university + specific risk indicator + timestamp - Category-B: user identity + university + pattern summary - Category-C: never identifies individuals — aggregate only

6.3 Retention

Data	Retention
Safeguarding alert audit log	7 years (post-incident), then secure deletion
Mood-tracking individual data	24 months rolling, then anonymised aggregate retained
Chat content	End-to-end encrypted on device ; server stores ciphertext only; deleted 90 days after chat closure
User account	Until account deletion + 30-day grace period

6.4 Subject Rights

Standard UK GDPR rights honoured within **30 days**: - Right of access (SAR) - Right to rectification - Right to erasure (with explicit caveats for safeguarding audit logs as permitted by Art. 17(3)(b)) - Right to data portability - Right to object

A dedicated **dpo@dequad.app** inbox handles all DSR requests.

7. Governance

7.1 Internal Roles

Role	Responsibility
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	Dequad CEO (with deputy = Clinical Advisor). Final decision authority on incidents.
Clinical Advisor	UK-registered Chartered Psychologist / Mental Health First Aid Instructor or equivalent. Owns the keyword taxonomy and quarterly review.
Data Protection Officer (DPO)	Either in-house from Year 2 or outsourced UK DPO firm from Year 1.
On-Call Safeguarding Officer	24/7 rotation; Mental Health First Aid trained minimum.
University Welfare Lead (external)	Each partner university's named safeguarding contact, named in the Data Processing Agreement.

7.2 External Advisory Board

A **UK Safeguarding Advisory Board** will be convened from Month 6, comprising: - 1 × UK university Mental Health Lead (rotating partner) - 1 × UK Chartered Psychologist - 1 × UK student representative (NUS or partner SU) - 1 × UK ICO / data protection expert - 1 × Lived-experience advocate (UK)

Meets quarterly. Reviews incident summaries (anonymised), policy changes, taxonomy updates.

8. Training

All Dequad personnel handling safeguarding data complete:

Training	Frequency
Mental Health First Aid (England) — 2-day certified course	Within 60 days of joining; refresher every 2 years
UK GDPR & ICO Data Protection	On joining + annual refresher
Suicide Prevention (Zero Suicide Alliance) — 20-min free module	On joining
Prevent Duty awareness (where applicable)	On joining
Internal Dequad Protocol Walk-through	On joining + on any protocol revision

University Welfare Leads receive a **Dequad Partner Onboarding Pack** within 5 days of contract signature, plus a 60-minute live walkthrough.

9. Incident Audit & Reporting

9.1 Per-Incident

Each safeguarding incident generates an immutable audit record:

- Unique incident ID
- Timestamp (UTC + UK local)
- User ID (pseudonymised in long-term store)
- University ID
- Category (A / B / C)
- Trigger (keyword / pattern / self-report / peer-report)
- Action taken (each step)
- Resolution outcome (where known)
- Lessons learned (if any)

9.2 Periodic Reporting

Report	Recipient	Frequency
Per-university anonymised incident summary	Partner Welfare Lead	Monthly
Aggregate UK trends report	All partner universities	Quarterly
Annual Safeguarding Transparency Report (public)	Public	Annually, March
Internal post-incident reviews	Dequad DSL + Advisory Board	Per incident (A & B)

9.3 Regulatory Reporting

Body	Trigger	Window
ICO	Personal data breach (likely to result in risk to rights)	72 hours
Partner university	Any Category-A incident involving their student	Real-time + post-incident report within 48 hr
Police (999 / 101)	If lawful disclosure required (e.g., immediate threat to life of identifiable third party)	Immediate, with legal advice

10. Limitations & Honest Disclosure

Dequad **does not** claim to: - Replace UK university counselling or NHS mental health services - Provide clinical diagnosis or treatment - Guarantee detection of all safeguarding concerns (no automated system can) - Operate as a clinical intervention service (it is an adjunct only)

These limitations are stated **in plain English** in the onboarding flow, in the in-app About screen, and in the Terms of Service.

11. Continuous Improvement

This protocol is reviewed: - **Quarterly** by the Clinical Advisor + DSL - **Immediately** after any Category-A incident - **Annually** by the UK Safeguarding Advisory Board - **On regulatory change** (OfS, ICO, UUK, NHS)

Each review produces a versioned, dated update. Previous versions are retained for 7 years.

12. Sign-Off

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Designated Safeguarding Lead (Dequad CEO)	[Founder Full Legal Name]	_____	_____
Clinical Advisor	[Clinical Advisor Name, registration number]	_____	_____
Data Protection Officer	[DPO Name / Firm]	_____	_____
Chair, UK Safeguarding Advisory Board	[Chair Name — to be appointed Month 6]	_____	_____

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